

Legislative Professionalism and Perceptions of White-Collar Government

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Abstract

The professionalization of American state legislatures is among the most consequential modern institutional reforms in legislative politics. Yet a core tension persists: citizens disapprove of professionalized legislatures even though these chambers possess capacity-enhancing resources—such as staff support, higher salaries, and longer sessions—that may improve representation and policymaking. We offer one explanation for this disapproval: citizens perceive professional legislatures as dominated by legislators from white-collar backgrounds. Consequently, we argue that opposition to professionalism stems, in part, from a belief that white-collar legislators may not represent society's interests broadly. Evidence from a preregistered conjoint experiment and observational analyses using the Cooperative Election Study (CES) supports this claim. Respondents associate professionalism with a legislature primarily composed of white-collar lawmakers, whom they do not believe govern to benefit the general public. These findings suggest that opposition to legislative professionalism likely reflects a rejection of white-collar government rather than repudiation of the institutional gains from professionalization.

Keywords: Legislative professionalism; Social class; Descriptive representation

American state legislatures have evolved over their modern histories, with many moving from low-capacity “citizen” chambers to more professionalized institutions holding substantial policy agendas and political power (Malhotra 2006; Squire and Hamm 2005). Some existing research finds that professionalized legislatures are, in principle, better equipped to provide policy representation than citizen legislatures with comparably fewer resources (Maestas 2000; Lax and Phillips 2012). This theoretical advantage reflects capacity-enhancing resources—such as staff support, higher salaries, and longer sessions—that facilitate policymaking and responsiveness (Maestas 2003; Harden 2016).¹ But despite these benefits, citizens, on average, report negative attitudes toward professionalized legislatures and often favor less-resourced citizen legislatures instead (Squire 1993; Kelleher and Wolak 2007; Richardson, Konisky, and Milyo 2012; Fortunato, McCrain, and Schiff 2023).

Why some citizens hold negative attitudes about professional legislatures, despite their enhanced capacity, remains unclear. We argue that the disapproval stems, in part, from aversion to white-collar legislators—such as lawyers, doctors, and educators—who are disproportionately represented in professionalized chambers (Carnes and Hansen 2016). Specifically, we contend that citizens associate white-collar lawmakers with professionalized legislatures and expect them to prioritize policies that benefit the wealthy at the expense of American society more broadly. This expectation is consistent with existing evidence documenting public skepticism toward professionalized chambers (Squire 1993; Kelleher and Wolak 2007; Fortunato et al. 2023; McCrain and O’Connell 2023). However, our argument clarifies that such disapproval is due, in part, to citizens’ perceptions that white-collar legislators are overrepresented in professional legislatures.

To test this expectation, we pair experimental and observational evidence from a preregistered conjoint experiment ($n = 1,996$) and the Cooperative Election Study (CES). We find that, across both surveys, respondents associate professional legislatures with white-collar legislators, who they believe prioritize policies that do not benefit the respondents themselves or society in general.

¹Although this existing evidence *suggests* that professional legislatures provide better representation broadly, the findings are not causally identified (see Achen 1978; Matsusaka 2010). Moreover, legislators’ preferences remain a dominant predictor of their behavior compared to those of constituents, whose central role is the selection of like-minded representatives (e.g., Matsusaka 2026).

This pattern suggests that at least a portion of citizens' disapproval of professional legislatures is rooted in opposition to their perceived class composition—not the institutional enhancements that come from greater legislative capacity.

Our findings offer important contributions at the intersection of political institutions and representation. First, they highlight a stark misalignment between citizens' representational preferences and the social-class composition of American legislatures. Although our results indicate that Americans are skeptical about the over-representation of white-collar legislators, fewer than 2% of state legislators come from working-class backgrounds (Carnes and Hansen 2024). Second, by linking attitudes toward legislative professionalism to perceptions of legislators' class backgrounds, we show how institutional reforms can shape public evaluations of representation indirectly—through the class backgrounds citizens associate with professionalized chambers. Finally, our findings add to a growing literature documenting the political consequences of workers' underrepresentation in American legislatures (Carnes 2013; Carnes and Lupu 2023; Lollis 2024) by demonstrating how class-based descriptive representation also conditions public support for legislative institutions.

Consequences of Legislative Professionalism

Beginning in the 1960s, under-resourced state legislatures initiated reform efforts through a process of professionalization, aiming to equip their institutions with capacity more comparable to those available to members of the U.S. Congress. These reforms were primarily aimed at raising legislators' salaries, expanding staff support, and lengthening time in session (Squire and Hamm 2005). Today, state legislatures vary widely in their level of professionalization. States such as New Hampshire, Wyoming, and Utah tend to pay legislators less, provide minimal staff support, and meet infrequently. In contrast, states such as California, New York, and Massachusetts have highly professionalized legislatures that function similarly to Congress.²

²Legislative professionalism in the American states is both theoretically and empirically defined relative to Congress, and varies continuously rather than discretely. The three traditional components of professionalism—session length, legislator salary, and staff support—are strongly correlated in Bowen and Greene's (2014) data spanning 1974–2019. Session length and salary correlate at +0.60; session length and non-salary legislative expenditures per legislator correlate at +0.41; and salary and expenditures per legislator correlate at +0.64, indicating that a legislature that is professional is less resource-constrained compared to part-time, citizen legislatures.

The resources that professionalism provides affect how legislators engage in policymaking (Jansa and Gray 2019; Kroeger 2022; Makse 2022), representation (Harden 2016), communication (Payson, Casas, Nagler, Bonneau, and Tucker 2022), and constituency service (Harden 2016; Landgrave and Weller 2020; Garcia and Sadhwani 2023). Professional legislatures, for example, are better equipped with tools to advance original legislation (Jansa and Gray 2019; Kroeger 2022). Some scholars find correlational evidence that they are associated with improved policy representation, although other studies report low levels of congruence (cf. Maestas 2000, 2003; Matsusaka 2010; Lax and Phillips 2012; Harden 2016; Simonovits, Guess, and Nagler 2019; Caughey and Warshaw 2022).

Professional legislatures also attract white-collar legislators (Carnes and Hansen 2016). Existing work finds that the higher salaries in professional legislatures attract white-collar candidates, increase electoral competition, and crowd out workers (Carnes and Hansen 2016). Fewer than 2% of legislators in chambers that pay over \$75,000 are from working-class backgrounds, compared to over 7% in chambers where lawmakers receive only a nominal salary (Carnes and Hansen 2016, 703). These findings indicate that although workers are numerically underrepresented in every state legislature (Lollis 2024), their exclusion is most extreme in professionalized chambers.³

Citizens' Attitudes Toward Professional Legislatures

On average, Americans hold clear preferences regarding the professionalization of the legislatures in their home states. When asked, respondents are less likely to approve of or have confidence in professional legislatures (Squire 1993; Richardson et al. 2012; Kelleher and Wolak 2007). As Kelleher and Wolak (2007, 713) note, “people report greater confidence in . . . statehouses that resemble the ideal of citizen legislatures than those that resemble the U.S. Congress.” However, while it is clear that citizens hold negative attitudes toward professional legislatures, the reasons *why* citizens may disapprove of institutions that are equipped with capacity-enhancing resources remain unclear.

³Table 5 in the appendix reports estimates of the association between legislative professionalism, legislators' salary, and the share of working-class legislators. These results show that workers are less likely to be represented in professional legislatures and legislatures with higher salaries.

One explanation is that citizens oppose the capacity-enhancing features of professionalized legislatures, such as higher salaries, expanded staff, and longer sessions. Prior work finds that, particularly as legislatures began to professionalize, citizens opposed these reforms at the ballot box largely because they increased legislators' pay (Squire 2012). More recent research, however, contradicts this perspective. Kirkland and Harden (2022) find that respondents in a survey experiment view legislatures with higher salaries or longer session lengths as better able to provide representation compared to low salary or short session chambers. Moreover, apparent opposition to professionalism could be partly informational; citizens are often poorly informed about state legislatures (Rogers 2023a) and providing information about how capacity-enhancing institutions can facilitate policies that benefit constituents substantially increases support for professional legislatures (Fortunato et al. 2023).

We offer an additional perspective to this multifaceted explanation of citizens' disapproval of professional legislatures. Citizens may object less to the particular capacity-enhancing institutional reforms associated with professional legislatures than to the *kinds of lawmakers* serving in these institutions. White-collar lawmakers are more prevalent in professional legislatures than in citizen legislatures (Carnes and Hansen 2016), and, accordingly, we expect that citizens associate legislative professionalism with white-collar representation—an attribute they tend to evaluate negatively (Griffin, Newman, and Buhr 2020). There are several reasons to expect this association. First, professional legislatures more closely resemble the structure and function of Congress, where white-collar government—and its consequences—are most visible (Carnes 2013). To the extent that citizens use Congress as a heuristic, they may infer that professionalized state legislatures are likewise dominated by white-collar lawmakers.

Second, citizens evaluate legislatures through the lens of perceived—rather than objective—descriptive representation (Stauffer 2021; Clark and Rogers 2025). Although state publics may be uncertain about the actual composition of their legislatures (Ahler and Sood 2018), they nonetheless form beliefs about who is included and excluded, and these perceptions shape their evaluations of both Congress and state legislatures (Stauffer 2021). For example, when underrepresented

groups perceive higher levels of their group's representation, their evaluations of a legislature improve—even when those perceptions are inaccurate (Stauffer 2021; Clark and Rogers 2025). If some citizens use professionalism as a cue for *who* serves in a legislature, then disapproval of professional legislatures may reflect perceptions that these chambers are dominated by white-collar lawmakers (which they are relative to citizen legislatures), rather than opposition to the capacity-enhancing resources that comprise the process of professionalization.

H1: Americans associate increased legislative professionalism with more white-collar representation.

Citizens' perceptions of which social groups are represented in legislatures shape their trust, perceived responsiveness, and external efficacy toward those institutions (Tate 2003; Stauffer 2021). When women and Black individuals perceive greater representation of their group, they are more likely to view legislatures as responsive (Harden and Clark 2016; Stauffer 2021; Clark and Rogers 2025). We argue that citizens apply this same heuristic to social class. If citizens perceive a legislature as disproportionately composed of white-collar lawmakers, they may expect it to be less responsive to the average American and more likely to produce policies that advantage affluent interests. As a result, some citizens may expect white-collar legislators to prioritize policies that are less likely to benefit people like them and the broader public.

H2: Americans believe that white-collar representatives are less likely to advance and pass policies that benefit people like them and society.

Taken together, we argue that some citizens' disapproval of professional legislatures is not driven by opposition to capacity-enhancing institutions. Instead, it stems, in part, from perceptions that white-collar legislators are overrepresented in professional chambers and from expectations about the kinds of policies these lawmakers prioritize in office.

Research Design

To test these expectations, we combine experimental data from a preregistered conjoint survey experiment with observational data from a module on the 2016 Cooperative Election Study (CES).

First, we fielded a preregistered, choice-based conjoint survey experiment through Prolific from March 28, 2024 through April 6, 2024 ($n = 1,996$).⁴ The sample was quota-matched to U.S. adult population benchmarks on age, gender, and race; full sample demographics are reported in the Supplemental Appendix. Given that many survey respondents likely did not have a clear definition of legislative professionalism going into the study, we began by providing a definition. We avoid using the term “legislative professionalism” directly in the definition because it could prime respondents to over- or understate their evaluations of professional legislatures. Specifically, the definition we gave respondents was as follows: “Legislative capacity is the resources a legislature needs to function. Legislative capacity varies across legislatures, with some legislatures having many resources and other legislatures having few resources.”

Respondents then answered a standard set of demographic questions that asked information about their age, income, occupation, partisanship, state of residence, and overall economic status. In the middle of the demographic question block, we included a pre-treatment “manipulation check” to assess whether respondents internalized our definition of legislative capacity. We included this question prior to treatment to avoid biased estimates that can result from dropping respondents based on post-treatment responses (Aronow, Baron, and Pinson 2019).⁵

Survey participants then completed five randomly assigned, pairwise comparisons between

⁴The preregistration plan can be found in Appendix Section 1. We specified subgroup-specific hypotheses (i.e., how white-collar and working-class respondents’ attitudes differ toward professional legislatures). In this paper, we argue that *all* respondents associate legislative professionalism with the class composition of a legislature and the policies it produces, irrespective of their class identity. Although the specific hypotheses in our preregistration differ slightly from those presented here, we include the preregistration to demonstrate that our expectations before conducting the conjoint experiment are consistent with the results and argument presented in this paper.

⁵We note that the pre-treatment questions and definitions in our study reflected the language of *legislative capacity*, rather than *legislative professionalism*, which was the concept we ultimately asked respondents to evaluate. Prior research demonstrates that most citizens have limited knowledge of state legislative institutions—especially when described using researchers’ terminology (Rogers 2023a,b). For this reason, we provided respondents with a brief, accessible definition of the core concept they were being asked to assess. While we believe it was necessary to offer a working definition to aid comprehension, we deliberately avoided a direct definition of professionalism to minimize priming effects. Moreover, the definition we provided was neutral: it framed legislative capacity as the basic resources a legislature needs to function. It was not a normatively positive portrayal of capacity, but rather a fact-based one. Finally, we do not maintain that citizens’ limited knowledge of state legislatures renders their attitudes nonexistent or unmeasurable. Indeed, existing research demonstrates that some citizens do have attitudes about legislative professionalism (Squire 1993; Fortunato et al. 2023). Instead, we argue that scholars can—and should—offer contextual information when asking about topics that may be difficult for respondents to conceptualize. In our view, supplying a definition of legislative capacity was both justified and necessary for this case.

two profiles of hypothetical legislatures (Legislature A and Legislature B). Each profile randomly varied a set of attributes. The key attributes were the three components of legislative professionalism—session length, staff support, and salary—and the legislature’s class composition (white-collar, working-class, or mixed). In this research we define class using occupation, consistent with standard practice in political science (Carnes 2013; Makse 2019; Carnes and Lupu 2023; Lollis 2024). To ensure respondents interpreted “white-collar” and “working-class” consistently, we provided definitions directly in the profiles that respondents evaluated. We described white-collar legislators as those “who formerly worked as lawyers, doctors, and educators,” and working-class legislators as those “who formerly worked as farmers, factory workers, and in clerical occupations.” All attribute levels and their possible combinations are listed in Table 1.

After reading each profile, respondents were then asked to select the legislature that best aligns with the following three outcome questions:

1. Which legislature is best positioned to benefit society?
2. Which legislature is best positioned to benefit people like you?
3. Which legislature is most professional?

We estimate conditional marginal means—rather than average marginal component effects (AMCEs)—for each of our three outcome measures. Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile is chosen when a given attribute level is present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes (Leeper and Tilley 2020).⁶ We code respondents’ class backgrounds using the same occupation-based definition of class used in the conjoint profiles.⁷

⁶Unlike AMCEs, marginal means do not require a reference category because they do not summarize effects relative to an omitted baseline, making them especially straightforward to interpret in subgroup comparisons (Leeper and Tilley 2020).

⁷Respondents are coded as working class if they report currently or previously working as a contractor, construction worker, office or clerical worker, public safety worker, retail or service worker, or in a trade job (Lollis 2024). All other respondents are coded as white-collar.

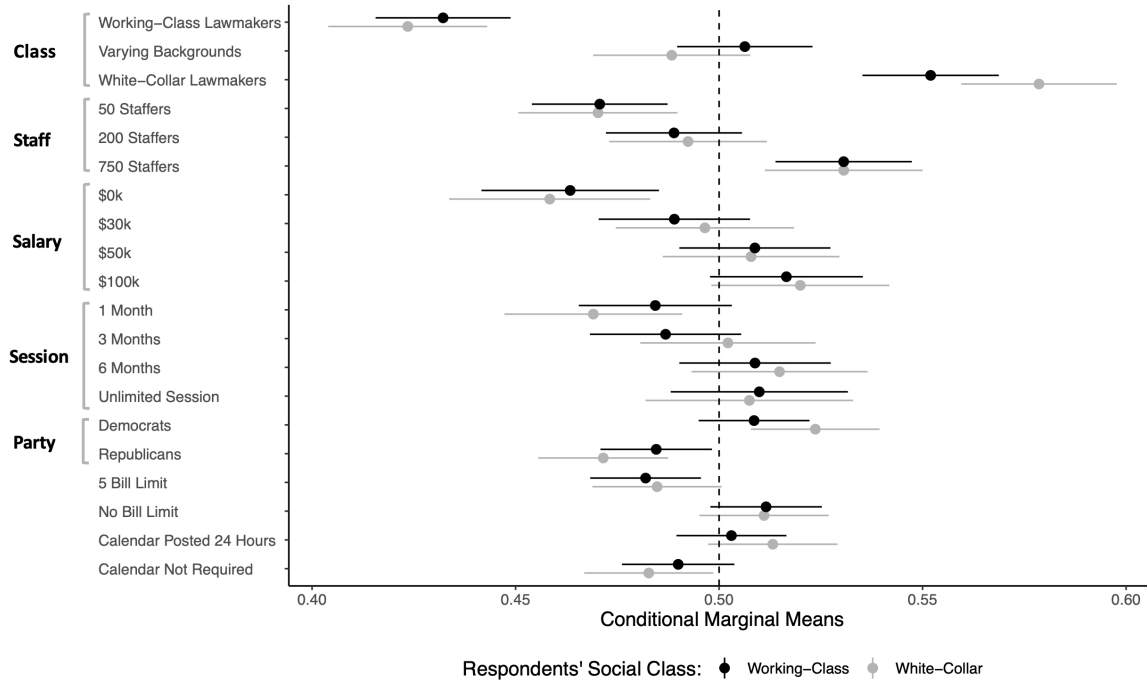
Table 1: All Potential Attributes for Choice-Based Conjoint Random Assignment

Feature	All Possible Options
Legislative session length	"1 month" OR "3 months" OR "6 months" OR "Unlimited"
Total legislature staff	"50 legislature staff members" OR "200 legislature staff members" OR "750 legislature staff members"
Legislator's salary	"\$0" OR "\$30k" OR "\$50k" OR "\$100k"
Class	"The newly elected legislature is made up primarily of white-collar legislators who formerly worked as lawyers, doctors, or educators." OR "The newly elected legislature is made up primarily of working-class legislators who formerly worked as farmers, factory workers, and in clerical occupations." OR "The newly elected legislature includes legislators from a variety of occupation backgrounds."
Party in Control	"Democrats" OR "Republicans"
Bill introduction limits	"5 bill limit" OR "Unlimited"
Session calendar posting Requirements	"Session calendars must be posted 24 hours before session convenes." OR "Session calendars are not required, permitting legislators to take up any desired issue."

Conjoint Experiment Results

Figure 1 reports conditional marginal means for responses to the third outcome question—"Which legislature is most professional?" Regardless of their own class background, respondents rated legislatures composed mostly of working-class lawmakers as less professional, and rated legislatures composed mostly of white-collar lawmakers as more professional. This pattern reflects a substantively large effect: the gap in perceived professionalism between predominantly working-class and predominantly white-collar legislatures is nearly 10 percentage points in the marginal means. Legislatures with a mixed class composition fall between the two extremes. These findings support H1: respondents associate professional legislatures with white-collar lawmakers. Respondents also rated legislatures with lower staff levels and lower legislative salaries as less professional. Importantly, these effects are smaller than the influence of class composition on perceptions of professionalism, which is consistent with our argument. Overall, respondents primarily equate professional legislatures with white-collar legislators.

Figure 1: Respondents Associated Professional Legislatures With White-Collar Lawmakers

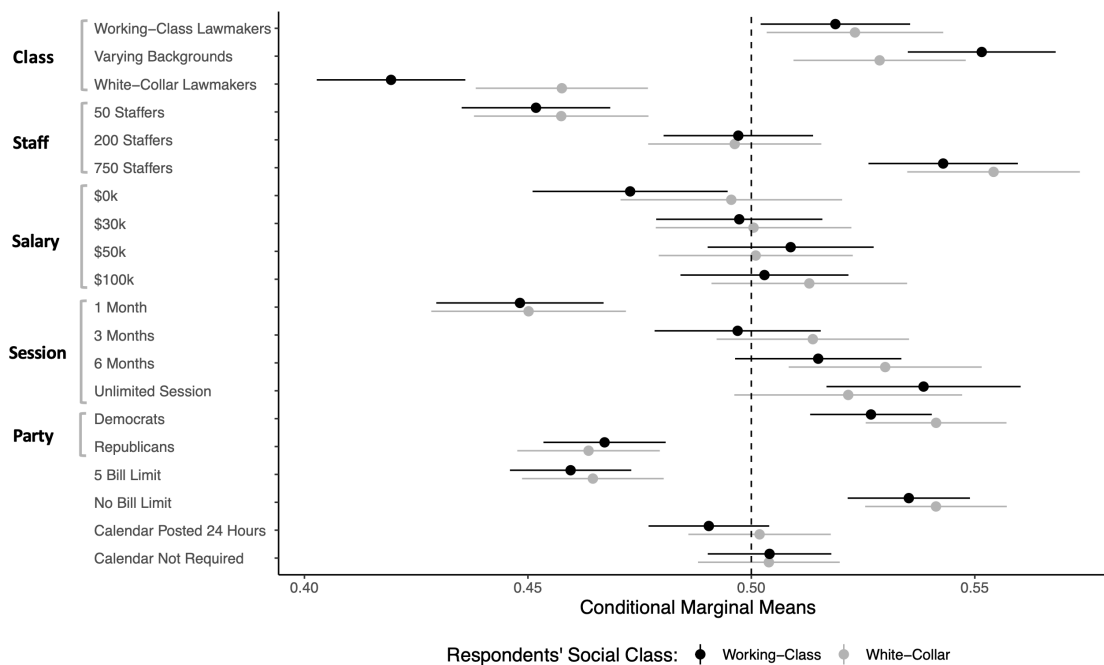


Note: Points represent conditional marginal means estimating the probability that respondents associated a professional legislature with legislators' class backgrounds, by institutional feature. Horizontal lines indicate 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are shown separately for working-class (black points) and white-collar (gray points) respondents. Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile was chosen when a given attribute level was present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes.

To test our second expectation, we asked respondents, “Which legislature is best positioned to benefit society?” Figure 2 reports the conditional marginal means for this outcome. Respondents perceived legislatures composed largely of white-collar lawmakers—those they also rate as most professional—as least well-positioned to benefit society. Notably, this pattern holds among both working-class and white-collar respondents. In contrast, respondents rated legislatures with mixed class compositions and those composed primarily of working-class lawmakers as better positioned to benefit society. The magnitude of this effect is substantively large: the gap in perceived societal benefit between predominantly working-class and predominantly white-collar legislatures is nearly seven percentage points. This finding is consistent with H2.⁸

⁸This effect should be interpreted as respondents' expectations about which legislature is better to generate societal benefits, rather than as a direct measure of actual policy outputs, given that the question asked which legislature was “best positioned,” not “most likely,” to benefit people like them (or society).

Figure 2: Respondents Viewed White-Collar Legislatures as Less Well-Positioned to Benefit Society



Note: Points represent conditional marginal means estimating the probability that respondents viewed a legislature as best positioned to benefit society, based on its class composition, by institutional feature. Horizontal lines indicate 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are shown separately for working-class (black points) and white-collar (gray points) respondents. Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile was chosen when a given attribute level was present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes.

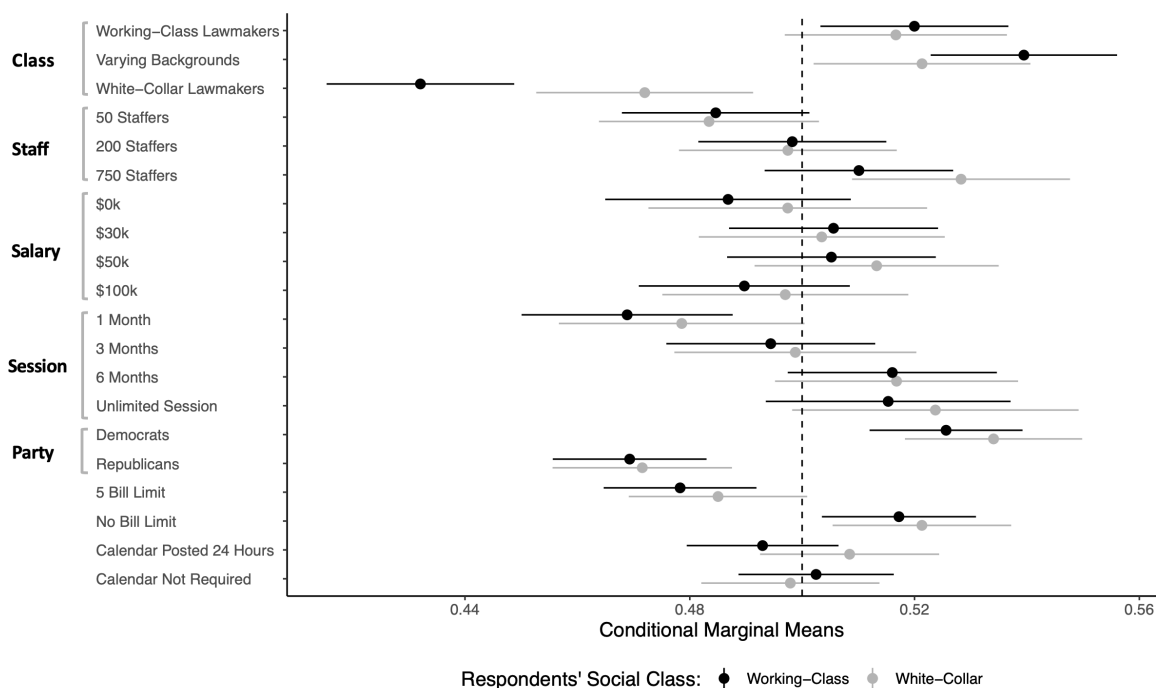
Our results also indicate that respondents viewed unlimited bill introductions, larger staff sizes, longer session lengths, and Democrat-controlled legislatures as more beneficial for society.⁹ In contrast to prior work finding that some citizens hold negative attitudes about professional legislatures (Squire 1993; Kelleher and Wolak 2007; Richardson et al. 2012), our findings suggest that state publics view larger staffs and longer sessions—two hallmarks of professionalized legislatures—as beneficial for society (see also Kirkland and Harden 2022). Consistent with our argument, however, respondents view white-collar representation in these chambers negatively. Together, these results indicate that aggregate disapproval of professional legislatures is not driven by opposition to capacity-enhancing institutions (which respondents evaluate positively), but in-

⁹This result likely reflects the fact that our sample was primarily made up of Democrats. We examine treatment heterogeneity by party in the next subsection.

stead reflects skepticism toward the white-collar representation that they associated with professionalized chambers.

To test our final expectation, we asked respondents “Which legislature is best positioned to benefit people like you?” Once again, results from Figure 3 indicate that both working-class and white-collar respondents rated legislatures composed primarily of working-class lawmakers as better positioned to benefit people like themselves, and rated predominantly white-collar legislatures as least well-positioned. The substantive magnitude is similar to the previous outcome: the gap between perceptions of predominantly working-class versus predominantly white-collar legislatures is nearly six percentage points in the marginal means.

Figure 3: Respondents Viewed White-Collar Legislatures as Less Well-Positioned to Benefit People Like Them



Note: Points represent conditional marginal means estimating the probability that respondents viewed a legislature as best positioned to benefit people like them based on its class composition, by institutional feature. Horizontal lines indicate 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are shown separately for working-class (black points) and white-collar (gray points) respondents. Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile was chosen when a given attribute level was present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes.

There is some heterogeneity by respondent class on this outcome: white-collar respondents

viewed white-collar legislatures as less beneficial than working-class respondents reacted to them. Still, both groups rated white-collar legislatures as least well-positioned to benefit people like themselves. This pattern is also inconsistent with the idea that high occupational class respondents recognize personal gains from white-collar representation even if they perceive broader societal harms. Overall, the weight of these results indicates that the American public—regardless of class identity—tends to associate white-collar representation with professional legislatures and believe that those legislatures are suboptimal for benefitting members of the public themselves or society in general. These results suggest support for H1 and H2.

Results by Respondent Party

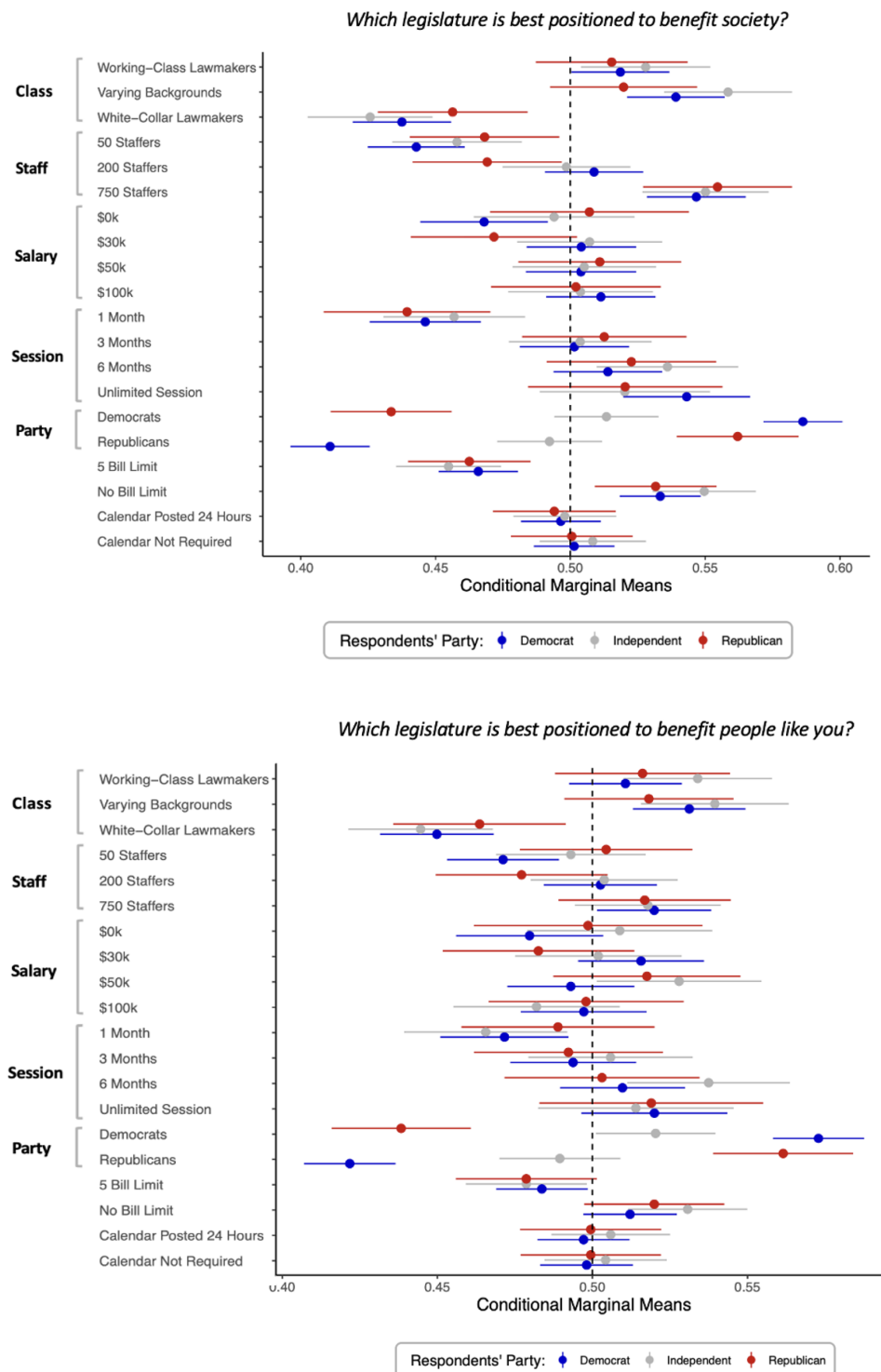
One concern is that our results may be moderated by respondents' partisanship. This possibility is plausible for two reasons. First, although our sample was quota-matched on age, gender, and race, it was not matched on party identification.¹⁰ Based on self-reported partisanship, the sample includes 968 Democrats, 420 Republicans, and 572 Independents. Given this imbalance, the pooled patterns we report may reflect the preferences of Democratic respondents more than those of Republicans or Independents. Second, the results reported above indicate that respondents rated Republican-controlled legislatures as less well-positioned to benefit themselves and society, suggesting that party control was a salient cue in their evaluations. If Democrats, Republicans, and Independents differ in how they weight class composition and capacity attributes, pooled estimates may mask party-based heterogeneity in responses.

To test for this variation, we conducted the analyses reported in Figures 2 and 3 disaggregated by respondent partisan identification. We find that the results do *not* vary by party. Put differently, they are not driven by an overrepresentation of Democrats in the sample. Democrat, Republican, and Independent respondents consistently viewed legislatures comprised of white-collar lawmakers as less beneficial, both to society (left panel) and themselves (right panel).¹¹

¹⁰This option was not available from Prolific at the time the experiment was fielded.

¹¹Disaggregating by respondents' partisan identification reveals modest heterogeneity in responses to non-class attributes. Figure 4 shows that Democrats and Independents reacted to legislatures with working-class or mixed-class lawmakers as better positioned to benefit society, whereas Republican respondents' evaluations are not statistically significant. A similar pattern appears for the "benefit people like you" outcome: Republicans did not favor working-

Figure 4: Respondents Viewed Working-Class and Mixed-Class Legislatures as Best-Positioned to Benefit Society and Respondents Personally, Regardless of Partisanship



Note: Points represent conditional marginal means estimating the probability that respondents viewed a legislature as best positioned to benefit society (left panel) or people like themselves (right panel), based on its class composition and institutional features. Horizontal lines indicate 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are shown separately by respondents' party identification (Democrat, Independent, Republican). Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile was chosen when a given attribute level was present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes¹³

Limitations of the Conjoint Experiment

Several limitations to our conjoint survey experiment are important to acknowledge. First, as with many conjoint designs, external validity is a concern. Although we find that respondents associate white-collar lawmakers with legislative professionalism—and, in turn, view white-collar legislatures as less responsive—these relationships may not translate directly to real-world settings. Conjoint experiments create an artificial decision environment in which respondents evaluate a fixed set of attributes, which could differ from how some citizens encounter and process information about legislatures outside of experimental conditions. Moreover, we provided respondents with a definition of legislative capacity at the start of the survey. We do not know whether these respondents would have responded similarly without this prompt. But lacking the prompt would have more closely resembled how citizens acquire information in the real world. To address these concerns, we complement the conjoint experiment with observational evidence from a CES module that measures respondents’ perceptions of social class representation. The CES data mitigates two limitations of the conjoint design: (1) it was not explicitly designed to study, and does not define, legislative professionalism; and (2) it was not embedded in an experimental setting, reducing concerns about external validity.

CES Observational Survey

To address the inherent limitations of our conjoint survey experiment, we draw on data from a 2016 Cooperative Election Study (CES) module designed by Carnes and Lupu (2022). In this survey—which was unrelated to the study of legislative professionalism—Carnes and Lupu (2022) measured class-related attitudes by asking respondents to (1) estimate the share of state legislators from working-class backgrounds in their states and (2) report the share they would prefer. We use these items to construct a variable, *Perceptions of Working-Class Underrepresentation*, which measures the difference between respondents’ preferred and perceived levels of working-class rep-

class or mixed-class legislatures, while Independents did. Democrats viewed mixed-class legislatures as positioned to be beneficial for themselves, but did not similarly favor exclusively working-class legislatures. Despite these differences, the subgroup results consistently indicate that respondents perceived predominantly white-collar legislatures as producing worse outcomes for both themselves and society, supporting H2.

resentation. Higher values indicate a stronger desire for more working-class lawmakers than respondents believed existed at the time; lower values indicate a preference for fewer working-class lawmakers. This variable ranges from -89 (perceiving far too many working-class lawmakers) to 100 (perceiving far too few), with a mean of 28.3 . We also create a measure, *Legislative Approval*, which captures respondents' approval of their state legislatures. Responses are based on the question: "Do you approve of the way each your state legislature is doing its job?" and range from 1 to 4 , with higher values indicating stronger legislative approval.

Together, these measures allow us to assess two additional empirical relationships: (1) whether (objective) state legislative professionalism is associated with citizens' perceptions of working-class underrepresentation, and (2) whether these perceptions are associated with lower legislative approval. The former allows us to assess whether our results hold in a non-experimental environment that did not define capacity and where professionalism was measured using objective indicators (Bowen and Greene 2014). The latter also enables us to test whether our main empirical findings hold in a non-experimental context, but using a measure of legislative approval rather than external efficacy (i.e., whether legislatures are positioned to respond to citizens' needs.) Importantly, the purpose of this CES analysis is to serve as a complement to the survey experiment—triangulating evidence and addressing limitations associated with the experimental design. It supports descriptive rather than causal inferences and should not be interpreted as testing a preregistered expectation.

To estimate the first relationship, we regress *Perception of Working-Class Underrepresentation* on each dimension of state legislative professionalism (Bowen and Greene 2014).¹² The first dimension is our independent variable of interest because it represents the primary variation in professionalism, correlating highly with the Squire Index (Bowen and Greene 2014, 288). We also control for a variety of relevant covariates measuring respondent characteristics and party control

¹²Building on the Squire Index (Squire 2017), Bowen and Greene (2014) leverage multidimensional scaling to uncover the underlying dimensions of commonly used professionalism indicators. The components of the Squire Index, of which Bowen and Greene use slight variants, are (1) the number of days a legislature is in session, (2) the size and/or investment in legislative staff, and (3) legislators' salaries. Their approach yields a two-dimensional structure that varies considerably across states and over time (in contrast to the unidimensional Squire Index).

of respondents' states at the time of the CES survey. Table 2 reports the results.

Consistent with our experimental findings, as the first dimension of professionalism increases, so too does the perceived gap between the proportion of working-class lawmakers that respondents want and those they believe exist, controlling for other confounders. In other words, those in more professionalized states hold stronger perceptions that white-collar lawmakers are overrepresented in their legislatures.¹³ This estimate is statistically significant and substantively large. A one standard deviation increase in legislative professionalism corresponds with an increase in the dependent variable by more than 5 percentage points, or about 17% of a standard deviation in the gap of perceptions. Paired with our experimental evidence, this finding suggests that legislative professionalism is associated with perceptions of class representation (H1).

¹³ Respondents were randomly assigned to state their class representational preferences for state legislators, members of Congress, and city council representatives. The results presented here do not disaggregate based on whether the respondent was randomly selected into either of these groups. In Section 4 of the Appendix, we subset the dependent variable based on whether the respondent was asked about a state legislature, Congress, or city council. Consistent with our expectations and findings here, the coefficient is positive and statistically significant for state legislatures, and not statistically significant for Congress or city council.

Table 2: Legislative Professionalism, Approval, and Perceptions of Class Representation

	(1) <i>Perception of Working-Class Underrepresentation</i>	(2) <i>Legislative Approval</i>
<i>Professionalism (1d)</i>	0.967** (0.455)	−0.012 (0.015)
Professionalism (2d)	−0.522 (1.131)	0.169*** (0.037)
<i>Perception of Working-Class Underrepresentation</i>	—	−0.005*** (0.001)
Respondent Education	−2.683*** (0.687)	0.004 (0.023)
Respondent is Female	−4.158** (2.099)	0.179* (0.069)
Respondent is Nonwhite	−9.540*** (2.600)	0.136 (0.086)
Democrat Control of State	−2.357 (3.776)	−0.354** (0.122)
Republican Control of State	4.821 (3.071)	−0.308** (0.102)
Respondent Birth Year	−0.231*** (0.060)	0.007*** (0.002)
Respondent is Democrat	2.022 (2.476)	0.007 (0.082)
Respondent is Republican	−1.971 (2.706)	0.117 (0.089)
Family Income	−0.034 (0.038)	−0.001 (0.001)
Intercept	494.187*** (119.033)	−10.820** (3.947)
Observations	886	688
Adjusted R ²	0.055	0.099

Note: Cell entries report regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. The dependent variable in Column (1) is the difference in respondents' preferences for working-class representation and their perceptions of working-class representation in legislatures. The dependent variable in Column (2) is state legislative approval. The survey responses come from the 2016 Duke University Cooperative Election Study module. Team survey weights are included in the analysis. * $p < 0.05$ (two-tailed).

To assess whether the general pattern of our experimental results hold when using legislative approval as the outcome rather than measures of external efficacy, we regress *Legislative Approval* on *Perception of Working-Class Underrepresentation*, controlling for the professionalism of the legislatures in respondents' home states. As perceptions of working-class underrepresentation increase, approval of the state legislature decreases, controlling for the rest of the model. Put

differently, respondents who believe there are too few working-class legislators report reduced approval of their legislatures, on average. This estimate is statistically significant and substantively meaningful: a two-standard deviation increase in perceived underrepresentation is associated with a 34% standard deviation decrease in legislative approval. These findings are consistent with H2.

Overall, we find a general pattern of support for our expectations outside of the conjoint experiment. Observed legislative professionalism is positively associated with the perception that working-class citizens are underrepresented in state legislatures and that perception predicts a drop in state legislative approval. While this secondary observational analysis falls short of causal identification, we view it as useful descriptive context that bolsters the results of the experiment. The weight of our evidence suggests support for the conclusion that the occupational class composition of state legislatures is one plausible explanation for state publics' aversion to the professionalization of their legislatures.

Conclusion

American state legislatures have professionalized over their modern histories, which scholars contend has largely expanded their policymaking power (Squire and Hamm 2005; Kousser 2005) and influence relative to other actors such as interest groups (Garlick, Kroeger, and Pellaton 2025) and the governor (Kousser and Phillips 2012; Birkhead, Harden, and Windett 2026). Yet despite the capacity-enhancing resources associated with professionalized legislatures, Americans hold negative attitudes toward them (Squire 1993; Kelleher and Wolak 2007; Richardson et al. 2012; Fortunato et al. 2023). In this paper, we offer one explanation for this reaction: citizens may disapprove of professional legislatures because they expect them to be dominated by white-collar lawmakers—a group many citizens view negatively. We combine evidence from a conjoint survey experiment with observational data from the CES and show that, across both analyses, some citizens associate legislative professionalism with white-collar representation and, in turn, perceive white-collar legislatures as less well-positioned to benefit themselves or society.

This research builds on existing work by showing that citizens' perceptions of descriptive representation—rather than objective group representation—shape legislative approval and efficacy

(Stauffer 2021; Clark and Rogers 2025). Our findings suggest that, like gender and race, perceived social class composition also conditions how citizens evaluate legislatures. When legislatures are composed primarily of white-collar lawmakers—a pattern most common in professional legislatures—citizens infer that these institutions are less well-positioned to benefit them or society broadly. Thus, state publics’ negative attitudes toward professionalization are less about their capacity to create policy and more about who citizens believe is actually carrying out that function.

Normatively, our findings identify a representational dilemma related to the capacity and composition of political institutions. Reforms designed to enhance legislative capacity may unintentionally deepen public skepticism if they also crowd out working-class legislators. Thus, even if professionalization improves lawmakers’ ability to produce policy and represent constituents, these resources may not translate into greater public efficacy or approval. Efforts to reform political institutions therefore cannot be evaluated solely in terms of capacity-enhancing resources. Instead, our findings suggest that support for legislatures depends critically on who citizens believe holds power within them. Reforms that increase institutional resources without addressing representational disparities may ultimately exacerbate the problems they are intended to solve.

Although our results indicate that some citizens view white-collar legislatures as poorly positioned to benefit themselves or society, it remains unclear whether these perceptions align with actual representation and policy outcomes. Existing work has been limited in assessing legislative responsiveness, in part because of identification challenges (Achen 1978; Matsusaka 2010). Future research may therefore examine whether citizens’ perceptions of unresponsive, white-collar government are empirically warranted using research designs that yield stronger causal leverage (e.g., Matsusaka 2026). It may be that professional legislatures—often dominated by white-collar lawmakers—are less likely to enact policies that advantage working-class Americans, and more likely to produce outcomes that disproportionately benefit the affluent. Evaluating these claims, however, requires credible causal identification. Future work should assess whether the public’s perceptions of white-collar government are reflected in observable policy outputs and distributional outcomes.

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1 Preregistered Research Design for Conjoint Survey

This section describes a preregistered choice-based conjoint survey experiment. This experimental design and pre-analysis plan were registered as the Open Science Framework on February 14, 2024, and can be found at [LINK REMOVED FOR ANONYMITY](#).

Ethics Information

This research complies with ethical regulations for research involving human participants. The proposed experimental study protocol has been approved by the Internal Review Board (reference # IRB-SBS-6131) by the UNIVERSITY NAME REDACTED FOR ANONYMITY. Informed consent will be obtained from all respondents prior to participation. Participants will be compensated for their participation.

Expectations

We hypothesize that white-collar Americans are more likely than working-class Americans to indicate approval of professional legislatures. Conversely, we expect working-class Americans to prefer amateur legislatures rather than professional legislatures. Given that professional legislatures are more likely than amateur legislatures to be comprised of legislators from a white-collar background (Carnes and Hansen 2016), we expect white-collar citizens to be comfortable with the idea that legislatures are comprised primarily of the economic elite.

We expect that the primary reason citizens prefer legislatures comprised of lawmakers from their own class background is because they believe these lawmakers are best suited to create effective public policy that benefits members of their own occupational class group. Specifically, we plan to test the set of hypotheses listed below.

H1: White-collar Americans are more likely than working-class Americans to indicate approval of professional legislatures.

H2a: White-collar Americans are more likely than working-class Americans to believe that professional legislatures create effective public policy for white-collar Americans.

H2b: Working-class Americans are more likely than white-collar Americans to believe that amateur legislatures create effective public policy for working-class Americans.

These hypotheses formalize the logic we laid out in our theoretical development earlier, indicating that preferences over legislative capacity are tied to Americans' own class backgrounds. That link arises because of their beliefs about the kinds of policies likely to be enacted by the lawmakers in those chambers.

Conjoint Experiment

To test our expectations, we propose administering a choice-based conjoint experiment. This experiment provides a better design than our pilot survey experiment because it will allow us to observe whether citizens' preferences toward legislative professionalism and the class composition of legislatures are multidimensional. For example, the proposed conjoint experiment will allow us to discern whether citizens' preferences regarding the class composition of legislatures is related to individual components of legislative professionalism, in addition to other potentially important variables like majority party status. By estimating component-specific treatment effects (Hainmueller, Hangartner, and Yamamoto 2015), we can better understand the relationship between citizens' occupational class backgrounds and their attitudes toward legislative capacity.

Respondents will view two profiles of hypothetical legislatures that are randomly created from a set of attributes. They will then be asked to select the profile that they most prefer. From this information, we can estimate the average marginal component effect (AMCE), which represents the "degree to which a given value of a conjoint profile feature increases, or decreases, respondents' support for the overall profile relative to a baseline, averaging across all respondents and other features" (Leeper and Tilley 2020, 207). We can also estimate the marginal mean (MM), which "conveys information about the preferences of respondents for all feature levels" instead of using a reference category (Leeper and Tilley 2020, 210).

Before completing the conjoint survey experiment, the survey will ask respondents a series of demographic questions (listed in Table 2). Respondents will also be asked questions probing their occupational class identity, measured holistically with income, education, and occupation

questions (see below).

Table 2: Demographic Questions and Possible Responses

Demographic Question	Possible Responses and Format
In what year were you born?	Select one: Drop down option of large year span
Which of the following best describes you?	Select one: A. Male, B.Female ,C. Non-binary, D. Prefer not to say
What is the highest level of education you have completed?	Select one: A. Did not graduate from high school, B.High school graduate, C. Some college, but no degree, D. 2-year college degree, E. 4-year college degree, F. Post-graduate degree (e.g. MA, MBA, MD, JD, PhD)
What race or ethnic group best describes you?	Select all that apply: A. White, B. Black or African American, C. Hispanic or Latino, D. American Indian or Alaska Native, E. Asian, F. Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander, G. Middle Eastern, H. Mixed Race, I. Other
Which of the following best describes your current employment status?	Select one: A. Working full-time now. B. Working part-time now, C. Temporarily laid off, D. Unemployed, E.Retired, F. Permanently disabled, G. Taking care of home or family, H. Student, I.Other
At any time over the past five years have you had a job?	Select one: A. Yes, B. No
Generally speaking, do you think of yourself as a Democrat, Republican, Independent, or what?	Select one: A. Democrat, B. Republican, C. Independent, D. Other
What is your state of residence?	Select one: Drop down list of all US states and territories
Would you say that over the past year your household economic situation has...	Select one: A. Increased a lot, B. Increased somewhat, C. Stayed about the same, D. Decreased somewhat, E. Decreased a lot
What is your total household income?	Select one: A. \$0 to \$19,999, B. \$20,000 to \$49,999, C. \$50,000 to \$89,999, D. \$90,000 to \$129,999, E. \$130,000 to \$149,000, F. \$150,000 +, G. Prefer not to say
Are you currently or have you ever been employed in construction, office or clerical work, retail, or in a skilled trade?	Select one: A. Yes, B. No
What is your current occupation?	Text box

In the experiment itself, respondents will view information about two legislatures (Legislature

A and Legislature B). Respondents will view seven features describing each legislature with multiple randomly assigned attributes (see Table 3). The features vary concepts related to legislative capacity such as legislative session length, total legislature staff, and legislator salary. We also include other relevant features such as the occupational class composition and partisan control of the legislature. For an example of a randomly assigned profile that a respondent may view, please refer to Table 4. After reading the feature and attribute information, respondents will be asked to evaluate each legislature relative to one another by responding to the following questions:

Q1: Which legislature is best positioned to benefit society?

Q2: Which legislature is best positioned to benefit people like you?

Q3: Which legislature is most professional?

We have revised our outcome questions following the pilot survey experiment to more directly probe how respondents' preferences are related to political representation. In the pilot survey experiment, we asked respondents to indicate what level of professionalism they thought their state legislature should have. Though this question asks respondents their preferences toward legislative professionalism, it does not connect their preferences toward professionalism to the quality of political representation they expect to receive. In the conjoint experiment, we will ask respondents to indicate which legislature is best positioned to benefit (1) *society* and (2) *people like them*. This strategy will allow us (and respondents) to distinguish between gains for the mass public as well as people who share characteristics similar to them.

First, respondents are shown the following definition of legislative capacity: "Legislative capacity is the resources a legislature needs to function. Legislative capacity varies across legislatures, with some legislatures having many resources and other legislatures having few resources." Respondents then answer a set of demographic questions. In the middle of the demographic question block, we ask a pre-treatment manipulation check question. To gauge how respondents conceptualize legislative capacity, we provide them information about two legislators (session length, salary, staff, occupation, etc.) and ask which legislator serves in the higher capacity legislature.

This allows us to isolate the respondents that did not internalize our definition of legislative capacity. We choose to ask respondents about two legislators (rather than two legislatures) to distance this question from the question format of our conjoint, which reduces the likelihood of priming effects. Finally, we follow the advice of Aronow et al. (2019) and ask our manipulation check question prior to the experimental manipulation to avoid biased estimates.

Respondents will iterate through five randomly assigned pairwise comparisons. Next, to ensure that respondents internalized the treatment, we will include a manipulation check. In line with existing literature, we plan to use a list-based manipulation check. After respondents iterate through all five comparisons, we will ask them to read a list of statements consisting of information specific to the profiles they viewed and check all the responses that are true (Zhang, Kreps, McMurry, and McCain 2020). For example, respondents will be asked to indicate whether each legislature was controlled by the same party. This information will allow us to determine whether respondents processed and internalized the various manipulations throughout the experiment.

Table 3: All Potential Attributes for Choice-Based Conjoint Random Assignment

Feature	All Possible Options
Legislative session length	"1 month" OR "3 months" OR "6 months" OR "Unlimited"
Total legislature staff	"50 legislature staff members" OR "200 legislature staff members" OR "750 legislature staff members"
Legislator's salary	"\$0" OR "\$30k" OR "\$50k" OR "\$100k"
Class	"The newly elected legislature is made up primarily of white-collar legislators who formerly worked as lawyers, doctors, or educators." OR "The newly elected legislature is made up primarily of working-class legislators who formerly worked as farmers, factory workers, and in clerical occupations." OR "The newly elected legislature includes legislators from a variety of occupation backgrounds."
Party in Control	"Democrats" OR "Republicans"
Bill introduction limits	"5 bill limit" OR "Unlimited"
Session calendar posting Requirements	"Session calendars must be posted 24 hours before session convenes." OR "Session calendars are not required, permitting legislators to take up any desired issue."

Table 4: Example of a Randomized Choice-Based Conjoint Profile

Feature	Legislature A	Legislature B
Legislative session length	1 month	Unlimited
Total legislature staff	50 legislature staff members	200 legislature staff members
Legislator's salary	\$0k	\$30k
Class	The newly elected legislature is made up primarily of white-collar legislators who formerly worked as lawyers, doctors, and educators.	The newly elected legislature is made up primarily of working-class legislators who formerly worked as farmers, factory workers, and in clerical occupations.
Party in Control	Democrats	Republicans
Bill introduction limits	5 bill limit	Unlimited
Session calendar posting Requirements	Session calendars must be posted 24 hours before session convenes.	Session calendars are not required, permitting legislators to take up any desired issue.

Planned Data Collection

We introduce two sets of restrictions to our design. We restrict the possibility that respondents will view identical profiles across the legislatures that are being compared. Additionally, we restrict the possibility that respondents will view a profile where legislators' salary is listed as \$0 and time in session is listed as unlimited. We restrict this comparison because it will likely be perceived as illogical by respondents. All other attribute pairings will be randomized.

Survey Vendor

We will administer the conjoint survey experiment through Prolific, a commonly used survey provider among political scientists that includes a nationally-representative sample among its product offerings. Prolific maintains its own survey pool and researchers then directly pay for their service as respondents. Respondents will be compensated for their time.

Sample

We will field our experiment on a nationally-representative sample of 1,500 U.S. Prolific respondents. To predict the statistical power of our design we used Stefanelli and Lukac (2020) power analysis Shiny application. With 1,500 respondents viewing 7 variable levels and completing 5 tasks at an AMCE effect size of 0.05 the predicted statistical power for our design is 93%. The probability of a Type S error occurring (incorrect sign) is 0% and the exaggeration ratio (Type M error) is 1.17.

Given that we are fielding a nationally representative sample, we largely expect our target population to align with our sample population. To ensure that this is the case, we have included several demographic questions that will allow us to empirically test the representativeness of our sample. In the demographic portion of the survey, we plan to ask respondents to disclose their age, state of residence, racial identity, and partisan identity. We will include a table in the manuscript listing the proportion of respondents for each of the categories.

Data Quality

To ensure that we are collecting the highest quality data from respondents, our survey includes both attention and comprehension checks, in addition to the manipulation check noted above. First, to ensure that respondents are paying attention while completing the survey, an attention check question will be randomly assigned to appear between one of the five comparisons. The question is: “What are the names of the two legislatures you are evaluating?” If respondents are paying attention, they should respond with “Legislature A and Legislature B.” Given that conjoint experiments are cognitively taxing for respondents, we deliberately chose an easier attention check.

Second, to ensure that respondents understand the required tasks within the survey, we will include an outcome question gauging their overall comprehension of the assignment. The final question respondents are asked to answer after reading the two legislature profiles for each task is: “Which legislature is more professional?” This question will allow us to empirically evaluate the percentage of our respondents who accurately conceptualize legislative professionalism while completing the survey. Finally, the survey vendor will drop any incomplete responses.

Analysis Plan

Variables

The independent variables in our analyses measure respondents' occupational class background. We take a holistic approach to measuring class by including questions about respondents' income, occupation, and education. The dependent variables in our analyses measure citizens' attitudes regarding varying levels of capacity and occupational class composition within legislatures. We ask respondents three questions gauging whether a given legislature is capable of crafting effective public policy. We also plan to include several control variables, including respondents' racial identity, gender identity, partisan identity, state of residence, and age. Each variable and its resulting coding structure is listed in Table 4.

Table 4: Variable List

Variable Type	Question	Variable Name	Coding Scheme
Dependent	Which legislature is best positioned to benefit society?	dv_1	0 = Legislature A 1 = Legislature B
Dependent	Which legislature is best positioned to benefit people like you?	dv_2	0 = Legislature A 1 = Legislature B
Dependent	Which legislature is most professional?	dv_3	0 = Legislature A 1 = Legislature B
Independent	Are you currently or have you ever been employed in construction, office or clerical work, retail, or in a skilled trade?	white_collar	0=Yes, 1=No
Independent	What is your total household income?	inc	0 = \$0 to \$19,999, 1= \$20,000 to \$49,999, 2= \$50,000 to \$89,999, 3 = \$90,000 to \$129,999, 4 =\$130,000 to \$149,000, 5= \$150,000 +, 6= Prefer not to say
Control	What year were you born?	age	Age = 2023 - birth year reported
Control	Which of the following best describes you?	sex	0 = Male, 1 = Female, 2= Non-binary, 3= Prefer not to say
Control	What race or ethnic group best describes you?	race	0= White, 1=Black/African American, 2=Hispanic/Latino, 3=American Indian/Alaska Native, 4=Asian, 5=Native Hawaiian/Pacific Islander, 6=Middle Eastern, 7=Mixed Race, 8=Other
Control	Which of the following best describes your current employment status?	work	0=Working full-time now, 1= Working part-time now, 2= Temporarily laid off, 3= Unemployed, 4=Retired, 5= Permanently disabled, 6=Taking care of home or family, 7= Student, 8=Other
Control	Generally speaking, do you think of yourself as a Democrat, Republican, Independent, or what?	PID	0=Democrat, 2= Independent, 3=Republican, 4= Other
Control	At any time over the past five years have you had a job?	job_5yrs	0=No, 1=Yes
Control	What is your state of residence?	state	String variable re-coded as state_fips

Evaluating Expectations

Given that we are interested in subgroup preferences (working-class v. white-collar), our primary estimand will be the difference between the conditional marginal mean for white-collar respondents and the conditional marginal mean for working-class respondents across our three outcome variables (Leeper and Tilley 2020). Though AMCEs are the typical estimand for conjoint analyses, marginal means are optimal for researchers interested in subgroup preferences (Leeper and Tilley 2020). The conditional marginal mean is calculated relative to a reference category, and is averaged across all other features (Leeper and Tilley 2020).

Evidence in support of our expectations would show that, averaging across the other features of the profiles, working-class respondents prefer amateur legislatures, particularly when professional legislatures are comprised of white-collar lawmakers. On the other hand, white-collar respondents will prefer professional legislatures, especially when they are comprised of white-collar legislators. To ensure that the observed effect sizes are substantively meaningful, we will use a two one-sided test (TOST) to test for equivalence (Lakens, Scheel, and Isager 2018). A TOST allows us to specify the effect size that would be negligible, and thus falsifying our hypotheses. We have chosen a 5 percentage point marginal mean change as the threshold for a non-negligible effect size.

Simulated Data

We use `DeclareDesign` to specify expectations and simulate potential effects and diagnostics (Blair, Cooper, Coppock, and Humphreys 2019). `DeclareDesign` allows researchers to define a model, an inquiry, a data strategy, and an answer strategy (Blair et al. 2019, p. 838). We declare a forced-choice conjoint design where respondents select one of two profiles. The model is set as a normal distribution with a sample size of 1,500. We pre-define two probability estimations. We expect that respondents will have a 95% probability of favoring a working-class legislature when session, staff, and salary variables are all consistent with the components of a citizen legislature. Conversely, we expect that respondents will have a 50% probability of selecting a white-collar legislature when session, staff, and salary variables are consistent with a professional legislature.

We specify these probabilities because they are consistent with our expectations, however, we are more interested in the resulting diagnostics than the estimand. All assignment declarations can be found in the appendix.

Using DeclareDesign allows us to estimate various diagnosands prior to administering our survey. We present four diagnosands relevant to the feasibility of our design—bias, RMSE, power, and coverage. Bias is zero in all conditions and coverage ranges from 94% to 96%. Power is greater than 50% in most conditions. These results, taken together with the power analysis presented in the sample portion of the report, broadly suggest that the number of features, attributes, and sample size of our design is sufficient to detect meaningful effects.

Table 5: DeclareDesign Diagnostics

Estimator	Sims	Bias	RMSE	Power	Coverage
Class (Working-Class Condition)	500	0.00	0.01	0.26	0.94
Class (Control Condition)	500	0.00	0.01	0.92	0.94
Salary (\$100k)	500	0.00	0.01	1.00	0.94
Salary (\$30k)	500	0.00	0.01	0.42	0.95
Salary (\$50k)	500	0.00	0.01	0.23	0.95
Session (3 months)	500	0.00	0.01	0.64	0.94
Session (6 months)	500	0.00	0.01	0.21	0.95
Session (Unlimited)	500	0.00	0.01	0.79	0.95
Staff (200)	500	0.00	0.01	0.55	0.95
Staff (700)	500	0.00	0.01	1.00	0.96

Design Table

Table 6 summarizes our design. This table aims to provide a succinct overview of our proposed research design. Specifically, it is organized around the research questions—and our expectations for those questions—featured in the manuscript. For each research question and subsequent set of expectations, we preview how we will administer our choice-based conjoint experiment. In doing so, we provide a discussion regarding the sampling protocol and the statistical power of our

design. Finally, we specify our primary estimand for each hypothesis and discuss the various ways in which results will be interpreted.

Question	Hypothesis	Sampling Plan	Analysis Plan	Interpretation Given to Different Outcomes
Does social class drive one's support for legislative professionalism and increased legislative capacity?	H1: Americans are more likely than working-class Americans to indicate approval of professional legislatures.	We will field a nationally representative survey of 1,500 U.S. respondents through Prolific. We also ask several demographic questions that will allow us to empirically test the representativeness of our sample. Given this, we expect that our target population will align with our sample population. We predict the statistical power of our design by using Lukac and Stefanelli's (2020) power analysis Shiny application. With 1500 respondents viewing 7 variable levels and completing 5 tasks at an effect size of 0.05, the predicted statistical power for our design is 93%. The probability of an Type S error occurring (incorrect sign) is 0% and the exaggeration ratio (Type M error) is 1.17.	Our primary estimand will be the difference between the conditional marginal mean for white-collar respondents and the conditional marginal mean for working-class respondents across our three outcome variables (Leeper et al. 2020). The conditional marginal mean is calculated relative to a reference category, and is averaged across all other features (Leeper et al. 2020).	We will interpret a statistically significant treatment effect in the predicted direction (see <i>H1</i>) as evidence that support for professional legislatures (at least partly) is driven by social class. If we observe no statistically significant treatment effect, we will test whether the treatment effect is small enough to be considered negligible, using equivalence testing. To ensure that the observed effect sizes are substantively meaningful, we will use a two one-sided test (TOST) to test for equivalence (Lakens et al. 2018). A TOST allows us to specify the effect size that would be negligible, and thus falsifying our hypotheses.
Does social class motivate the perception of how effective a legislature is at solving public problems?	H2A: White-collar Americans are more likely than working-class Americans to believe that professional legislatures create effective public policy for white-collar Americans. H2B: Working-class Americans are more likely than white-collar Americans to believe that amateur legislatures create effective public policy for working-class Americans.	We will field a nationally representative survey of 1,500 U.S. respondents through Prolific. We also ask several demographic questions that will allow us to empirically test the representativeness of our sample. Given this, we expect that our target population will align with our sample population. We predict the statistical power of our design by using Lukac and Stefanelli's (2020) power analysis Shiny application. With 1500 respondents viewing 7 variable levels and completing 5 tasks at an effect size of 0.05, the predicted statistical power for our design is 93%. The probability of an Type S error occurring (incorrect sign) is 0% and the exaggeration ratio (Type M error) is 1.17.	Our primary estimand will be the difference between the conditional marginal mean for white-collar respondents and the conditional marginal mean for working-class respondents across our three outcome variables (Leeper et al. 2020). The conditional marginal mean is calculated relative to a reference category, and is averaged across all other features (Leeper et al. 2020).	We will interpret a statistically significant treatment effect in the predicted direction (see <i>H2A</i> and <i>H2B</i>) as evidence that income is related to respondents' believing that legislatures sufficiently solve public problems. If we observe no statistically significant treatment effect, we will test whether the treatment effect is small enough to be considered negligible, using equivalence testing. To ensure that the observed effect sizes are substantively meaningful, we will use a two one-sided test (TOST) to test for equivalence (Lakens et al. 2018). A TOST allows us to specify the effect size that would be negligible, and thus falsifying our hypotheses.

2 Conjoint Survey Experiment Demographics

Conjoint Sample	
Partisanship	
Democrats	48%
Independents	28
Republicans	20
Gender	
Women	49
Men	49
Non-binary	2
Race and ethnicity	
White	70
Black	14
Hispanic	11
Other	5
Level of education	
Less than high school	1
High school	12
Some college	19
Two-year degree	10
Four-year degree	41
Advanced degree	15
Income level	
\$29,999 or lower	18
\$30,000-59,999	27
\$60,000-89,999	22
\$90,000-119,999	13
\$120,000-149,999	10
\$180,000-209,999	4
\$210,000-239,999	2
\$240,000-269,999	1
\$270,000-299,999	1
\$300,000 and above	1
Average age	58.7

Note: Cell entries are percentages except for the bottom row, which shows the mean age for each survey.

3 Conjoint Survey: Pre-manipulation Check

As a part of our conjoint survey, in the middle of the demographic question block, we ask a pre-treatment manipulation check question. To gauge how respondents conceptualize legislative capacity, we provide them information about two legislators (session length, salary, staff, occupation, etc.) and ask which legislator serves in the higher capacity legislature. This allows us to isolate the respondents that did not internalize our definition of legislative capacity. We choose to ask respondents about two legislators (rather than two legislatures) to distance this question from the question format of our conjoint, which reduces the likelihood of priming effects. Finally, we follow the advice of Aronow et al. (2019) and ask our manipulation check question prior to the experimental manipulation to avoid biased estimates. We examine whether the results of our analyses differ for those who answer the pre-treatment check correctly or not in Figure 1. We can see that for those who failed the pre-treatment check, the effects of the conjoint features are much less certain across all features. However, we still see for both those who passed and failed the pre-treatment check, there remains a lower likelihood of selecting a legislatures of mostly white-collar lawmakers as being good for society or people like respondents.

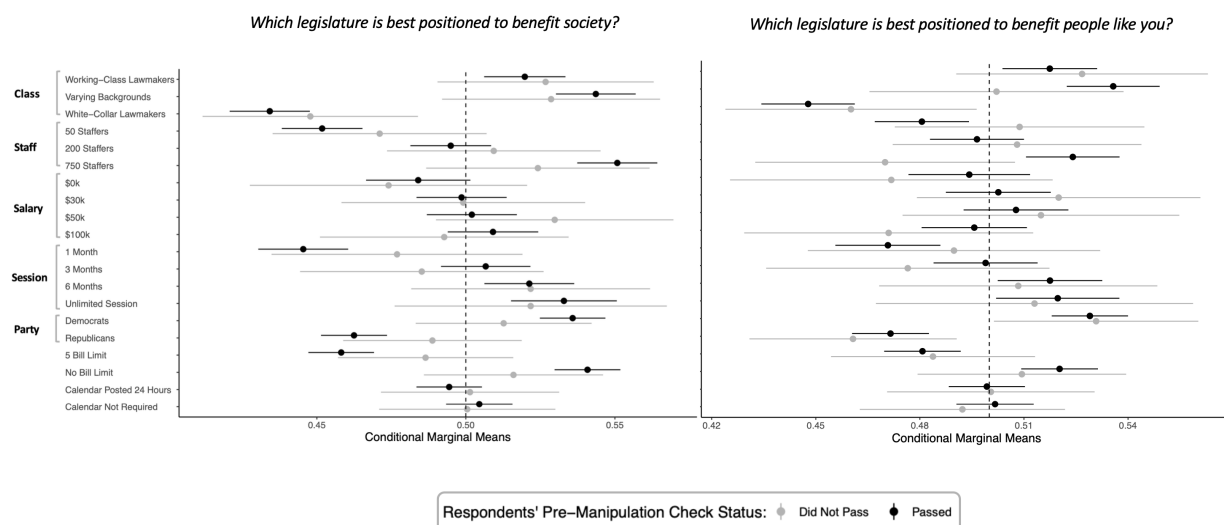


Figure 5: Conditional Marginal Means of Respondents' Selection of Which Legislature is Most Likely to Benefit Society and Themselves by Passage of Pre-treatment Check

4 2016 CES Survey Data (Carnes and Lupu 2022)

Carnes and Lupu embedded a word choice experiment in their survey question design. Specifically, they asked respondents “Some people think that more politicians should come from working class jobs. Others think more should come from white-collar professions. In an ideal world, what percentage of [members of Congress / state legislators in your state / the people on your town’s city council] would you want to come from the working class?” and randomized whether respondents saw members of Congress, state legislators in your state, or town council members. Our results in Table 2 (in text) are not conditioned on which office respondents saw, and thus, relate the effects of professionalism in state legislatures on respondents’ general feelings about the class of all representatives. However, we would expect that the effects of state legislative professionalism should be most obvious for state legislators. Thus, we split our analysis in the table below by the treatment assigned to respondents by Carnes and Lupu. It is important to note here that this dramatically reduces our statistical power, as each analysis is now examining approximately 300 respondents. Thus, we relax our discussions of statistical significance to the 0.10 level to better reflect the lower power of these statistical analyses.

The results of our subsample analyses based on the experimental treatment of Carnes and Lupu appear in Table 1 below. The analysis suggests that the first dimension of legislative professionalism makes respondents more likely to believe their state legislature is overrepresented by those from white-collar backgrounds. We see no statistically significant effects of professionalism on perceptions of members of Congress or City councilors, though those effects are also pointed in a positive direction. This suggests that most of the effect of professionalism observed in Table 2 (in text) is driven by a connection between state legislative professionalism and beliefs about the class backgrounds of state legislators, whereby respondents in more professional states believe their state legislature to be overrepresented by those from white-collar backgrounds.

Once again, across both an experimental design and an observational design, we find consistent evidence in support of both H1 and H2. Respondents to surveys associate professionalism with white-collar representation and associate white-collar representation with poorer policy out-

Table 1: Legislative Professionalism and Perceptions of Class Representation across Levels

	<i>Dependent variable</i>		
	State Legislature	Congress	City Council
Professionalism (1d)	1.187* (0.681)	1.250 (0.834)	0.385 (0.794)
Professionalism (2d)	1.330 (1.636)	0.537 (2.091)	−3.206 (1.964)
Respondent Education	−2.227* (1.085)	−2.979* (1.214)	−1.475 (1.178)
Respondent is Female	−2.933 (3.188)	−5.772 (3.797)	−3.857 (3.581)
Respondent is Nonwhite	−9.135* (3.948)	−9.048* (4.857)	−6.304 (4.289)
Democratic Control of State	−4.835 (5.868)	2.501 (6.723)	−1.263 (6.284)
Republican Control of State	2.176 (4.537)	14.128* (5.470)	−2.210 (5.335)
Respondent Birth Year	−0.487* (0.089)	−0.210* (0.111)	−0.054 (0.101)
Respondent is Democrat	3.784 (3.835)	1.344 (4.451)	0.217 (4.120)
Respondent is Republican	−1.324 (4.013)	−0.404 (5.126)	−2.187 (4.778)
Family Income	−0.025 (0.048)	−0.058 (0.070)	−0.230* (0.090)
Intercept	998.905* (174.189)	455.886* (219.729)	135.975 (200.033)
Observations	290	291	305
Adjusted R ²	0.124	0.061	0.025

Note: Cell entries report regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. The dependent variable is the difference in respondents' preferences for working class representation and their perceptions of working class representation in legislatures. The survey responses come from the 2016 Duke University Cooperative Election Study module. Team survey weights are included in the analysis. * $p < 0.10$ (two-tailed).

comes for both themselves and society. Respondents also associate capacity enhancing institutions with more professional chambers and better outcomes for society, but those associations are much weaker than our class-related treatments.

5 Additional Models

Table 5 reports the relationship between legislative professionalism and the socioeconomic composition of state legislatures, specified two ways. The dependent variable across both models is the percentage of workers in a state legislature (1987-2018) (Lollis 2024). The primary independent variable in Model 1 is legislative professionalism; the primary independent variable in Model 2 is annual legislator salary (Squire 2017). The models conditions on term limits and include state fixed effects. Both coefficients are negative and statistically significant, indicating that as chambers become more professionalized (and provide higher wages to legislators), the share of working-class legislators declines. These findings are consistent with our argument and existing work demonstrating that workers are less likely to be represented in professional legislatures (Carnes and Hansen 2016).

Table 2: Workers Are More Likely To Serve in Citizen and Lower-Paying Legislatures

	(1)	(2)
	% Workers in Legislature	% Workers in Legislature
Professionalism (Squire)	-1.426*** (0.117)	
Legislator Salary		-0.00000547*** (0.000000719)
Term Limits	-4.242*** (0.198)	-4.200*** (0.198)
Intercept	7.323*** (0.0334)	7.165*** (0.0306)
<i>N</i>	51929	51929
State Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

6 Professionalism Components

In the main body of the manuscript, we provide evidence that Bowen and Greene’s professionalism index is correlated with survey respondents’ perceptions of the under-representation of

the working class in state legislatures. This could be because the index itself is correlated with these perceptions or because one of the component parts of the index (legislative salary, legislative staff expenditures, legislative session length) is associated with these perceptions. To investigate whether the components of the index or the index itself predicts these attitudes, Table 6 reports the estimated relationship between the component parts of the professionalism index and the gap in respondents' perceptions of the under-representation of the working class in state legislatures. As the table indicates, the components of the professionalism index are uncorrelated with respondents' perceptions of working class underrepresentation, suggesting that it is the latent concept of professionalism itself that predicts these attitudes, rather than any one part of that latent concept.

Table 3: Legislative Professionalism Components, Approval, and Perceptions of Class Representation

	<i>Perception of Working-Class Underrepresentation</i>
Session Length	0.020 (0.013)
Legislative Salary	−0.030 (0.033)
Staff Expenditures	0.001 (0.001)
Respondent Education	−2.695*** (0.687)
Respondent is Female	−4.127** (2.099)
Respondent is nonwhite	−9.727*** (2.600)
Democrat Control of Leg	−1.497 (3.904)
Republican Control of Leg	4.358 (3.065)
Respondent Age	−0.226*** (0.061)
Respondent is Dem	2.291 (2.483)
Respondent is Rep	−1.778 (2.711)
Respondent Income	−0.032 (0.038)
Constant	481.577*** (119.327)
Observations	886
Adjusted R ²	0.055

Note: Cell entries report regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. The dependent variable is the difference in respondents' preferences for working-class representation and their perceptions of working-class representation in legislatures. The survey responses come from the 2016 Duke University Cooperative Election Study module. Team survey weights are included in the analysis. * $p < 0.05$ (two-tailed).